F Major

Scale Practice Worksheet · One flat: B♭ · 4 octaves

SCALES

01 Scale, Parallel and Contrary Motion

Begin in two octaves, then extend to four. Add contrary motion — one hand ascending while the other descends simultaneously.

The main difficulty in F major is fingering. With only one black key, the hand has few landmarks, and it is easy to confuse the 3rd and 4th fingers as the scale crosses over.

02 Scale in Thirds

The right hand plays the scale a third above the left — starting with F in the left and A in the right, a major third because the key is major. Two starting fingerings are valid: begin with the 2nd finger, or with the 3rd. Whichever feels natural is fine.

Once parallel motion is comfortable, add contrary motion.

> **TIP**
> Listen for the hands moving together. The right hand is more powerful and tends to dominate the ear; the left is where unevenness hides.

03 Scale in Tenths

A tenth feels like a third — the only difference is that the right hand plays one octave higher. The shape under the hand is identical. Add contrary motion.

> **TIP**
> Listen to the left hand. The right hand is louder and easier to track, but the left hand is what determines whether the scale sounds even. The more the left hand is practiced, the more even the scale becomes.

04 Scale in Sixths

For sixths, the left hand stays on the tonic — F — and the right hand moves to D, a sixth above.

Once the shape is comfortable, play it at a fast tempo. Playing fast is the test that reveals where the technique stands. To gain speed, add accents:

Step 1 — Accent every fourth note. Once that feels comfortable, the hand will start to move in groups.

Step 2 — Accent every eighth note. The longer grouping pulls the hand forward and lets it move faster.

> **TIP**
> When the left hand falls behind, isolate it and bring it up to the right hand's evenness — not the other way around.

ARPEGGIOS & CHORDS — TONIC, F MAJOR

05 Tonic Long Arpeggio

Play **F – A – C – F** as a long arpeggio across the keyboard, ascending and descending. Practice all three inversions:

Root position **F – A – C – F**

1st inversion **A – C – F – A**

2nd inversion **C – F – A – C**

For root position, the 4th finger may feel more comfortable than the 3rd at the crossover. Hand shapes differ — use whichever finger lands more naturally.

> **TECHNIQUE**
> The secret to long arpeggios is moving together with the hands. Sit comfortably. Feel the center of the body, and stay balanced as the hands travel across the keyboard. Try the motion without playing first — slide the hands across the keys to feel where comfort breaks down. Sitting with the legs closed makes balance worse; place the right leg slightly to the side for support. The body should stay flexible throughout, never disconnected from the hands. Use wrist rotation, not just the fingers — the wrist carries the hand across each shape change.

06 Six Long Arpeggios

Play six long arpeggios in sequence — three inversions of F major, each followed immediately by its parallel minor:

1) **F major** — root position: **F – A – C**

2) **F minor** — root position: **F – A♭ – C**

3) **F major** — 1st inversion: **A – C – F**

4) **F minor** — 1st inversion: **A♭ – C – F**

5) **F major** — 2nd inversion: **C – F – A**

6) **F minor** — 2nd inversion: **C – F – A♭**

Play each as a long arpeggio across the keyboard, then move immediately to the next shape. The goal is to play all six in a row without breaking the line.

The most important thing is legato. Stay legato through every transition between chords — this is what the exercise trains.

To increase difficulty, add contrary motion to each long arpeggio in the sequence.

> TIP
> This is a stamina exercise. Some muscle work in the hands and forearms is expected — that is the point.

CHROMATIC SCALE

07 Chromatic Scale from F

Play the chromatic scale starting from F across the full keyboard.

Two fingerings are useful:

Standard — 3rd finger on each black key, thumb on each white key. Where two white keys sit next to each other, use the 2nd finger and thumb.

Alternate — across the group of three black keys, incorporate the 4th finger. The fingering is `1-2-3-4` on **G – A♭ – A – B♭**. The wider hand position gives the hand a moment to relax between thumb crossings.

To add control, stop on every third note as a rhythmic variation.

> **TIP**
> The alternate fingering with the 4th finger feels strange at first, but it makes more sense once it becomes familiar. Try both — the one that allows the hand to stay relaxed is the one to keep.

08 Chromatic Scale in Double Octaves

Play the chromatic scale with each hand doubling at the octave. Add contrary motion.

> **TIP**
> Stop on the moments that feel uncomfortable. Don't ignore them — those are the points the exercise is designed to expose.

VARIATIONS

Contrary Motion

Any scale or arpeggio exercise can be played in contrary motion — one hand ascending while the other descends simultaneously. Harder than parallel motion and excellent brain training.

Accent & Rhythmic Variations

Apply to any scale or arpeggio exercise for fluidity and evenness:

a — Accent every note: extra weight on each individual note.

b — Accent every second note: grouped, rolling feel.

c — Triplet groupings: organize the scale in groups of three.

d — Groups of four: organize the scale in groups of four.

e — Prolong one note per group: hold the 2nd or 3rd note slightly longer to build control.

f — Groups of seven: the scale normally falls in groups of eight, so grouping in sevens shifts the accent and exposes unevenness.

Staccato

Any scale exercise can be played staccato — lift from each key rather than connecting the notes. Treat it as a separate pass, not a replacement for legato practice.

GENERAL PRACTICE PRINCIPLES

- Play with the whole body, not just the hands. Even the feet work when playing piano. The body stays engaged and flexible throughout the practice.
- On scales with few black keys, fingering is the trap. Confusion between the 3rd and 4th fingers is the main issue when most of the scale is white. Lock the pattern in slowly before playing at speed.
- Playing fast is a test of technique. To check where the hands stand, take a familiar scale up to tempo and listen for what breaks first.
- Practice the left hand. The right hand is louder and dominates the ear, but the evenness of the scale is determined by the left.